

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

TO RECLAIM THE COLOUR SAFFRON

A mosque demolition at Saharanpur has critics accusing the ruling BJP of using it for tactical Hindutva signalling

another ticking clock. The ruling BJP faces the next assembly election, due early 2027, with its Hindutva narrative bereft of its past impetus. Its diminishing firepower has been visible since 2024, when the Lok Sabha election produced a shocker four months after the Ram temple inauguration—with a tally nearly halved to 33 seats. In 2026, the Ayodhya temple theft episode has put many more holes in the sail. BJP watchers say Hindutva signalling now gets a more sceptical reception, especially from the youth who are asking urgent socio-economic questions.

So why double down on it? The Opposition charges that Hindutva is not optional for the BJP—it remains the primary calling card for vast segments of its flock. The only thing to do, say critics, is to raise the embankments and prevent the erosion of more turf. The saffron-robed, crusading image of chief minister Yogi Adityanath is the best bet for this, and low-grade 'confliction' a la Saharanpur offers the least injurious path.



Takeaways

- **A century-old masjid falls, after court, magistrate in Saharanpur act on Bajrang Dal complaint**
- **CM Yogi, facing scepticism post Ayodhya temple theft charges, is seeking to renew the voters' faith**
- **BJP govt says they are only following court orders, claims every demolition had judicial backing**

THE CORE INVESTMENT

So the script plays out with monotonous regularity—mostly at the municipal theatre, with state-level headline potential. In Moradabad, the Mustafa Mosque, off the Delhi-Lucknow highway, has been fighting a notice since August, accused of coming up without "an approved map". In Ghaziabad this June, six bulldozers razed 14 shops near the Jama Masjid in Begumabad in one of the district's biggest anti-encroachment operations. In Sambhal, a quieter, lower-profile demolition drive ran through much of 2025.

Talking to INDIA TODAY, state BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi took cover behind the court orders, and claimed there is no political vendetta at play. "They call these [demolitions] politically inspired, but should the government stop all activity close to an election?," he asks. Even with the Begumabad demolitions, the district administration put out a statement claiming they had only levelled three of the 14 'illegal shops'; the others were apparently brought down by the owners themselves.

The critics too see the pattern; the administration flatly pointing to court orders. Yogi's fiat against namaz on the roads—first aired last year, revived this year in Lucknow—again drew old lines of polarisation. A newer path offers itself with Union home minister Amit Shah's exhortation that every BJP/NDA state bring in a Uniform Civil Code. But the Adityanath regime, wary of handing the Opposition a new campaign plank, is not inclined to roll it out before the 2027 poll. The BJP's allies don't seem too keen on inviting a new complication anyway: the RLD, Apna Dal (S) and SBSP are pointedly reticent. So it's safer to turn to the trusty old bulldozer. ■